

Adobe University Hackathon 2026

Round 2 Practice Pack: Probable Case Study Questions

Theme: Speak to Agents - The New Language of Brand Visibility

Format mirror: 45 minutes, one sitting, one attempt | Practice only (not official)

Use this under a timer. Draft answers like the real round: analysis + strategy + actions.

CASE A | AuraWear (DTC Apparel) loses AI recommendations

AuraWear is a mid-size Indian D2C apparel brand. Classic SEO is fine: many category pages rank on page 1 for 'organic cotton tees', 'workwear shirts women', etc. Monthly organic sessions are stable.

But when shoppers ask AI assistants things like 'best sustainable everyday wear brands in India under 2000 INR' or 'good formal shirts for college placements', ChatGPT / Perplexity / Gemini often recommend 3-4 competitors and never mention AuraWear. When AuraWear does appear, the answer misstates pricing and calls it a 'premium luxury' brand.

Internal notes from the growth team:

- robots.txt blocks several AI crawlers; CDN returns 403 to unknown bots on /collections/*.
- Product pages are heavily client-rendered (JS). Key specs sit behind tabs.
- Blog last major refresh: 11 months ago. Few FAQ blocks in natural Q&A form.
- Wikipedia page is a stub. Reddit / Quora mentions are rare vs Competitor NovaKnit.
- Sample prompt board (20 prompts): AuraWear mention rate 15%, citation rate 5%, avg sentiment mixed/negative on price. NovaKnit mention rate 60%, citation 35%.
- Analytics shows almost no agentic bot hits on PDP URLs; a few hits on old blog posts.

Q1. Diagnose (8-10 min)

What are the top 3 reasons AuraWear is invisible or misrepresented in AI-generated answers despite decent SEO? Separate technical, content, and offsite/earned-media causes.

Think about:

- SEO vs GEO differences
- crawlability / JS / freshness
- third-party mention gaps and wrong brand narrative

Q2. Metrics (6-8 min)

Design a simple measurement plan for the next 8 weeks. Which metrics would you track across AI platforms, how often, and how would you know if the brand is actually winning visibility (not just traffic)?

Think about:

- mentions, citations, sentiment, position, share of voice
- agentic traffic vs referral / zero-click
- prompt clusters, not vanity homepage hits

Q3. Strategy (10-12 min)

Propose a prioritized 30-day action plan (quick wins vs deeper work) for onsite and offsite GEO. Be specific. Tie each action to the diagnosis in Q1.

Think about:

- robots/CDN, FAQs, content refresh
- Wikipedia / reviews / PR / community mentions
- what NOT to do first

Q4. Product / agent angle (8-10 min)

Imagine AuraWear's growth lead wants an 'agent-era brand visibility' workflow (monitor prompts -> find gaps -> fix content -> prove impact). Outline the workflow and what a tool like Adobe Brand Visibility (or a student-built agent) should automate vs leave to humans.

Think about:

- *prompt library + competitor bench*
- *opportunities queue + deploy/rollback thinking*
- *how you'd prove ROI to leadership*

CASE B | FinClear (fintech) - trust, YMYL, and wrong AI answers

FinClear offers a student credit-builder card and a basic savings vault in India. Compliance is strict. The website ranks okay for branded queries, but AI answers often:

- Confuse FinClear with a failed 2022 neo-bank with a similar name.
- Quote outdated fees from an old Moneycontrol article.
- Skip FinClear entirely for 'best student credit builder India 2026'.
- Cite a Reddit thread where an angry user alleged 'hidden charges' (later resolved).

Legal will not approve aggressive marketing claims. Product pages exist but are dense and legalistic. Help Center is good but buried. Competitor PulseCard dominates AI answers via review-site roundups and a strong Wikipedia page.

Q1.

In a YMYL (Your Money or Your Life) category, why can negative or outdated third-party content hurt FinClear more in LLM answers than in classic Google search? What does that imply for brand safety in the agent era?

Q2.

List the highest-leverage offsite and onsite fixes FinClear should pursue in order. Explain what 'authoritative, neutral, updatable' content means for AI citations.

Q3.

Propose 5 prompt clusters FinClear should monitor weekly (example format: intent + sample prompt). For each, say what 'winning' looks like (mention only vs preferred recommendation vs accurate fee citation).

Q4.

Leadership asks: 'If AI answers reduce clicks (zero-click), why invest in GEO at all?' Write a concise business case linking visibility, trust, and downstream conversion for a fintech brand.

CASE C | Quick prompts bank (speed drill)

Answer any 3 in 15 minutes total. Keep each answer under 160 words. Bottom line first.

Drill 1

A brand blocks GPTBot 'for security'. Traffic from ChatGPT referrals is near zero and mentions are falling. Do you unblock? What safeguards would you add?

Drill 2

Competitor is cited more because of one evergreen 'best of' listicle from 2024. Your product changed. What is your 2-week counter-plan?

Drill 3

Agentic traffic hits /blog/old-guide.html but never PDPs. What does that tell you, and what would you change on-site?

Drill 4

Mention rate is high but sentiment is negative on price. Is that a GEO win? What would you optimize next?

Drill 5

You can only ship one thing this sprint: schema+FAQ on top 10 URLs, OR a PR push for 3 review sites. Pick one and defend it for a fashion D2C brand.

Drill 6

Explain SEO vs GEO to a non-technical founder in 6 bullets without jargon overload.

Drill 7

Design a 'prompt war room' for a 3-person student team building a hackathon prototype around brand visibility agents. What screens/features are must-have for Round 3/4?

CASE D | Full mock paper (closest to real format)

Timebox: 45:00 | Suggested split: read 5 | Q1 10 | Q2 8 | Q3 12 | Q4 8 | buffer 2

Do not use the internet. Write as if this is the Unstop attempt.

NovaHost is a cloud hosting company targeting Indian startups. SEO is strong for 'cheap VPS India' and docs are solid. In AI assistants, NovaHost appears in ~25% of relevant prompts, but usually in position 3-4 with neutral-to-weak sentiment ('okay for beginners'). Competitor OrbitCloud appears first with phrases like 'best developer experience' and gets cited from GitHub READMEs, Hashnode posts, and a popular comparison table.

Data snapshot (last 30 days, 50 tracked prompts across ChatGPT + Perplexity + Gemini):

- NovaHost: mention 25%, citation 8%, avg position 3.4, sentiment 0.1 (near neutral)
- OrbitCloud: mention 70%, citation 42%, avg position 1.6, sentiment 0.6
- Agentic bot success rate on NovaHost docs: 61% (many 404s on old /v1/ API paths)
- Top losing prompt cluster: 'best hosting for student hackathon projects India'
- Top winning prompt cluster (rare): 'NovaHost pricing' (branded)

Question 1

Analyse NovaHost's brand visibility problem. What does the data imply about discovery, authority, and technical readiness for AI agents?

Question 2

Recommend a strategy to improve NovaHost's presence specifically for the losing hackathon/student prompt cluster within 4 weeks. Include onsite and offsite moves.

Question 3

Which 4 metrics would you put on an executive dashboard, and what decision would each metric drive? Avoid vanity metrics.

Question 4

Propose a lightweight 'Speak to Agents' solution idea (feature set + user flow) that helps brands like NovaHost monitor and improve AI answer visibility. Keep it realistic for a student hackathon build.

Answer frame (use on every question)

- 1) One-line bottom line
- 2) 2-3 causes tied to case facts
- 3) Prioritized actions (quick vs later)
- 4) How you measure success
- 5) Optional one-line Adobe/agent angle

Judging lens from Unstop: analytical thinking, strategic approach, actionable insights. Sound like a sharp student analyst - specific, not buzzwordy.

Disclaimer: Unofficial practice set inferred from the public theme and Adobe Brand Visibility / GEO materials. Official Round 2 content may differ.